It was extraordinary how British authority ceased to function

**A revealing incident is reported in 'British Soldier Looks at India,' being letters of Clive Branson. Branson was an artist and a communist. He served in the International Brigade*

in Spain, and in 1941 joined the Royal Armoured Corps, in which he was a sergeant. He

was sent to India with his regiment in 1942. In February, 1944, he was killed in action

in Arakan in Burma. He was in Bombay in August, 1942, after the arrest of the Congress

leaders, and at a time when the people of Bombay were seething with anger and passion and

were being shot down. Branson is reported to have said: ' What a clean healthy nationalism

you have! I asked people the way to the Communist Party's office. I was in uniform. Men

like me were shooting unarmed Indians, and naturally I was a little worried. I wondered

how I would be treated. But everyone whom I asked was anxious to help—not one tried

to insult or mislead me.'

over many areas, both rural and urban, and it took many days,

and sometimes weeks, for a 'reconquest', as it was often termed.

This happened particularly in Bihar, in the Midnapur district